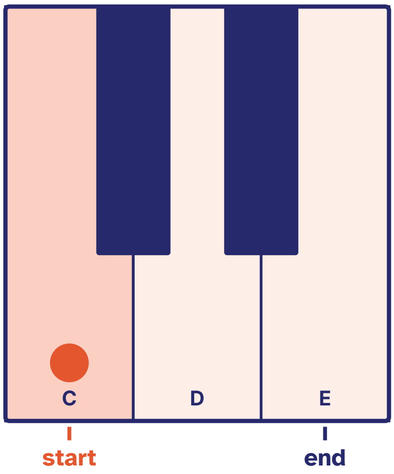
PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Left is **low**, right is **high**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**. Each group has a first white key, just to its left: **C** for the two, **F** for the three. Find the group, find its first key, then walk on.

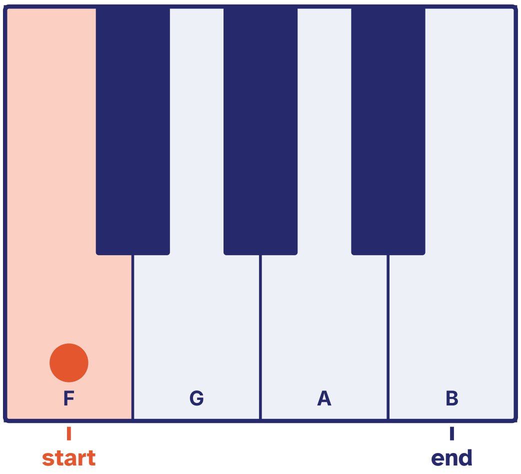
THE SECRET

Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.



2 black keys: C D E

on the piano E and F touch

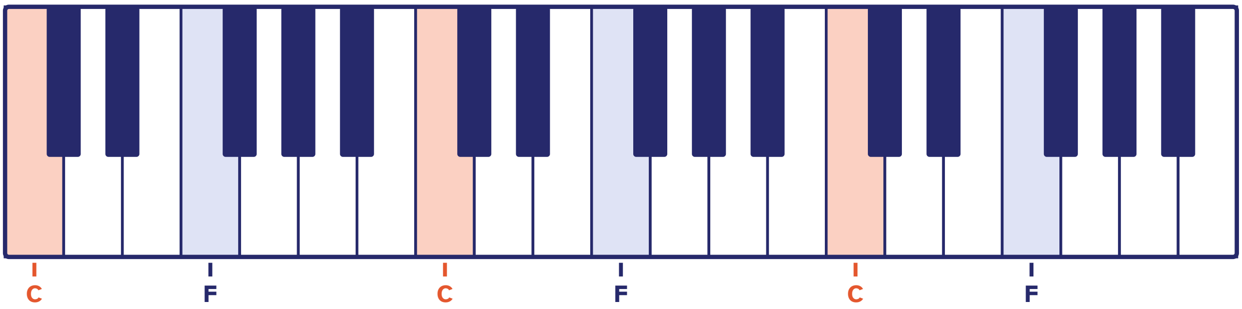


3 black keys: F G A B

Pulled apart: C starts the two, F starts the three · E and B end them

THE RULE

Find the group, then its first key. Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.

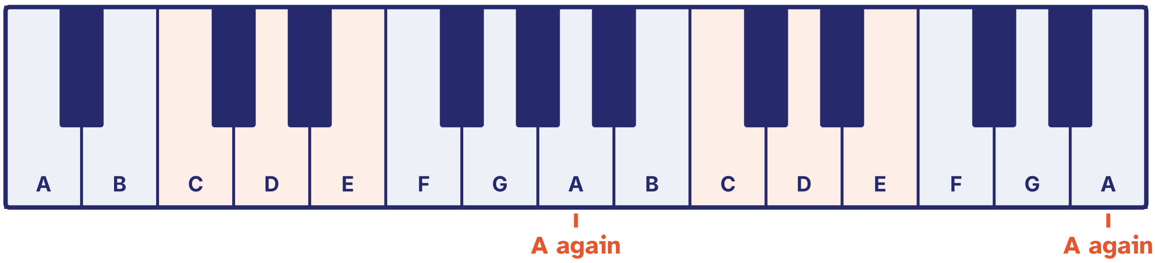


The pattern repeats all the way along: every two starts on C, every three on F

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

Seven letters, round and round

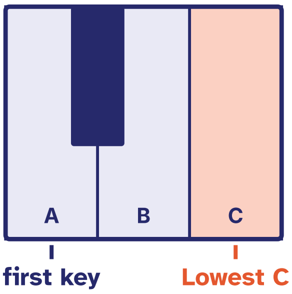
The white keys use only seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. There is no H. After G the next key is **A** again, and the seven letters go round and round, like the days of the week, all the way up the keyboard. **C D E** always sit round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three.



A B C D E F G, A B C D E F G, A ...: after G, back to A

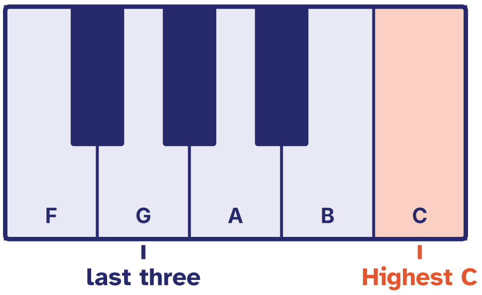
Where the keyboard starts

The very first key, bottom left, is an **A**. Look at the black keys there: only **one**, on its own. It is a group of three that has been cut off: only its end is left. The end of F G A B is **A B**, so the piano starts on A. After A and B comes the first full group of two, and its first key is **Lowest C**.



Where it ends

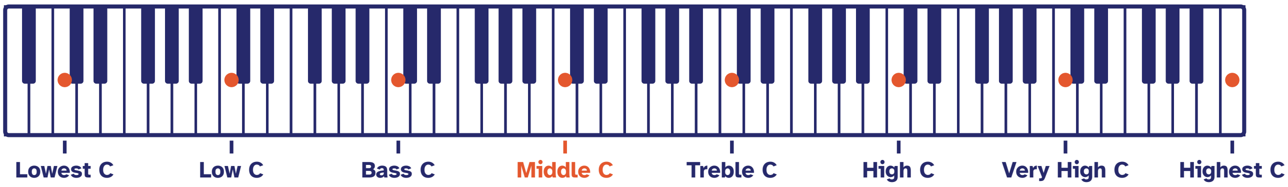
The very last key, top right, has **no black key** after it. Look left: the last group is **three** black keys, F G A B. After B comes C, the first key of a new group of two that was never built. So the last key is a **C**: **Highest C**.



The eight Cs have names

Count the Cs from the bottom and there are eight. The C nearest the middle is **Middle C**. Either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. At the ends: **Lowest C** at the bottom, then **Very High C**, and **Highest C**, the very last key. From one C to the next is an **octave**: C D E F G A B C, eight notes, both Cs counted.

Theory books and apps number them instead: C1 to C8, with Middle C as C4.

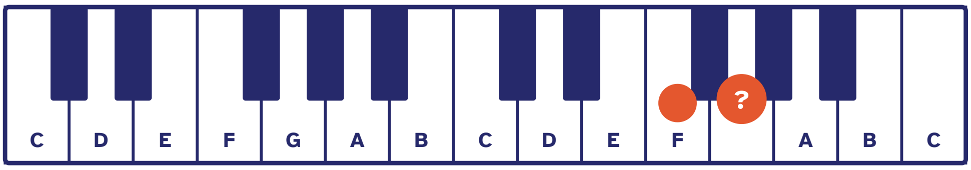


All 88 keys, eight Cs: the five in the middle are the ones you will use most

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Find G



① **Which family?** G is in F G A B: look for **three** black keys.

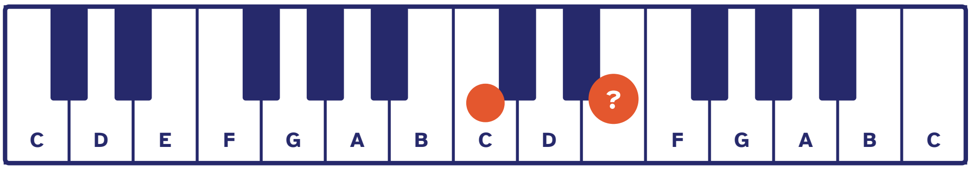
② **Find its first key:** F, just left of the three (the red dot).

③ **Walk on one key.** That is the **?**.

The **?** is **G**: the key after F. No need to start from C and count five.

EXAMPLE 2

Find E



① **Which family?** E is in C D E: look for **two** black keys.

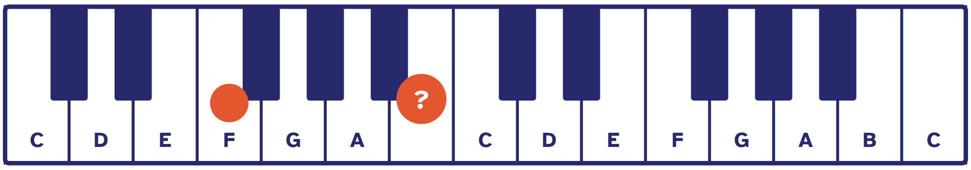
② **Find its first key:** C, just left of the two (the red dot).

③ **Walk on:** C, D ... the third key is the **?**.

The **?** is **E**: the last of the C D E family, just right of the two black keys.

EXAMPLE 3

Find B



① **Which family?** B is in F G A B: three black keys.

② **Start on F** (the red dot).

③ **Walk on:** F, G, A ... the last key of the family is the **?**.

The **?** is **B**: the last of F G A B, just right of the three black keys.

GAME

Which family?

1	2	3	4	5	6
D	A	F	E	B	G

Does each white key live with the **two** black keys (start on C) or the **three** (start on F)?

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 three (the first) · 4 two (the last) · 5 three (the last) · 6 three.

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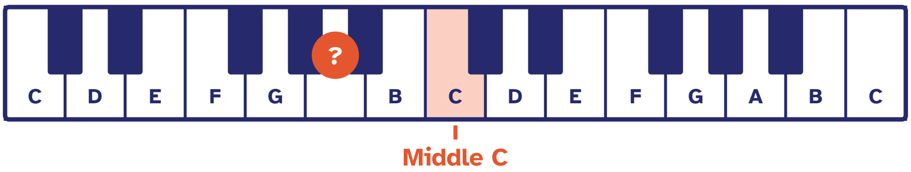
EXAMPLE 4

Find the A below Middle C

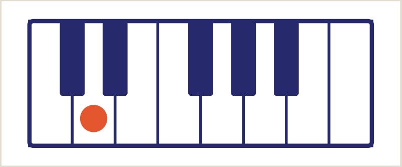


1. **Which family?** A is in F G A B.
2. **From Middle C, look left** for the nearest three black keys, and start on their F.
3. **Walk on:** F, G … the third key is the **?**.

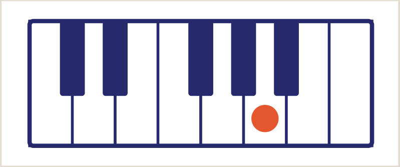
The **?** is **A**: F, G, A. Find the family first, and every key is at most three steps away.

GAME

Name the key



1



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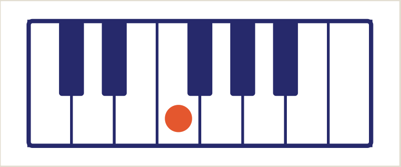


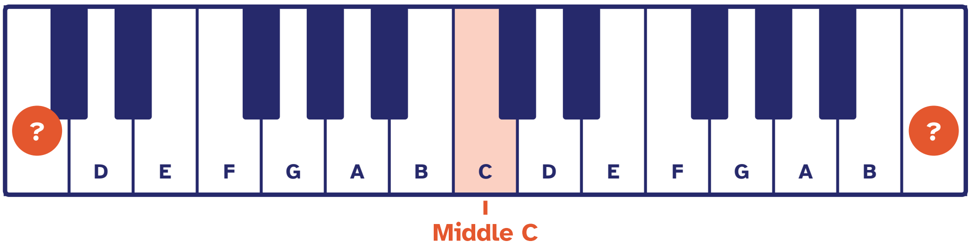
3

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Name each red key.

Answer: 1 D (C, then D) · 2 A (F, G, A) · 3 F (the first of the three).

EXAMPLE 5

Find Bass C and Treble C



1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave, eight notes, from Middle C.

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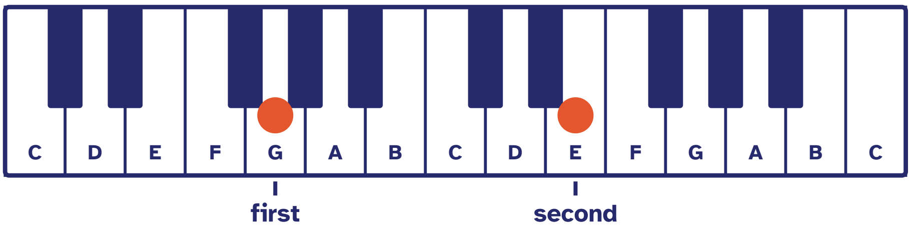
EXAMPLE 6

Higher or lower?



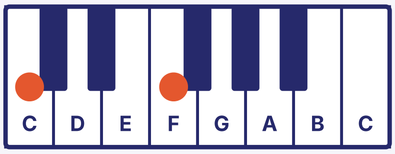
① **Find the two red keys.**

② **Which one is further right?**

③ **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

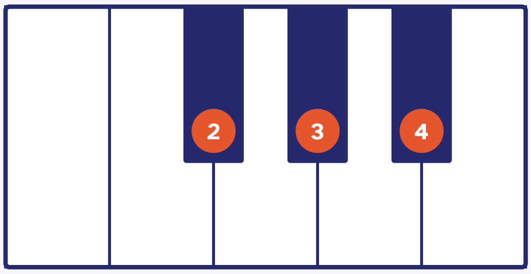


Play every C, then every F.

Bottom to top, saying the names: Lowest C, Low C, Bass C, Middle C, Treble C, High C, Very High C, Highest C. Then every F: left of the three.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Right hand, fingers **2 3 4** on the three black keys. Play from the top: **4 3 2**, 4 3 2, then 2 2 2 2, 3 3 3 3, 4 3 2. A whole tune, and not one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

TRAP

× Counting every key from C: find the nearest group and start from its C or F.

× Mixing up the families: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO
The staff and the clefs p. 27 · The staff and the keyboard p. 33

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 1 · Online: Library › Keyboard